

associated primarily with rarity or price. Today, producers say the concept has broadened to include sustainability, provenance, and craftsmanship.

“For us, luxury in tea has never meant extravagance,” says Chatterjee. “It means rarity, purity and a deep connection to nature. A truly luxurious tea reflects its terroir—the soil, the altitude, the weather, and the people who nurture it.”

At estates like Makaibari in Darjeeling, leaves are hand-plucked and processed in small batches, often using biodynamic farming methods. The result is tea that varies subtly from season to season, an attribute prized by connoisseurs. Mass-market teas, by contrast, are designed for consistency and produced in large volumes. Luxury tea embraces variation and scarcity, explains Chatterjee. A legendary tea from his estate is the Silver Tips Imperial—a rare moonlight-plucked tea made only from tender buds. It is considered one of the finest and rarest teas from Darjeeling. It is priced at ₹1,950 for 50 gm.

The new consumer driving this shift is not just the traditional tea collector. Increasingly, it is the younger, wellness-oriented buyer.

“India has always been a major tea-producing country, but we are now seeing it evolve into a far more



health- and wellness-conscious consumption market,” says Annapurna Batra, Chief Operating Officer of Newby Teas India. The luxury tea company offers various exotic teas, including a collection from British designer Mathew Williamson, where each caddy is designed by him. The gift set is priced at ₹14,000.

The pandemic accelerated this shift. As consumers began prioritising health and immunity, many turned to green, herbal, and white teas that promised both flavour and functional benefits.

International labels like TWG Tea, which launched in Singapore in 2008 and now offers more than a thousand single-estate teas and proprietary blends, have helped elevate tea into the realm of lifestyle

luxury. Their ornate packaging and salon-style tea rooms frame tea as both indulgence and ritual.

Indian brands are also entering the space. Boutique labels such as Hillcart Tales, No. 3 Clive Road, San-cha Tea and Vahdam are marketing curated collections that emphasise terroir, storytelling and modern flavour profiles.

Hillcart Tales offers imaginative blends like Apple Strudel (₹990), Caramel Dream (₹830), Blood Orange (₹1,020), teas designed to satisfy dessert cravings.

Then there are rare teas such as Swarna Panam, an Assam black tea infused with 24-carat edible gold flakes, priced at roughly ₹2.5 lakh for 1 kg. These ultra-premium teas function as both luxury collectibles and statement gifts.

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